



Pro gaming: A story

A fascinating account of one pro gamer from Chile and his love of fighting games
<http://dgit.in/16CHikR>



Google Now improved

The already amazing but spooky Google Now has new features for travel and entertainment. We wonder which card will it pull up now. <http://dgit.in/GooNow>



This month we highlight some aspiring tech writers and their spirited attempt to get published in the magazine. Let's have more!

Readers' write-ups



Uddip Talukdar

Leap Motion Controller Review

I was *Googling* 'molecular structure' and a series of careless clicks lead me to a website where they claimed they are making a software to build virtual molecules, and the software would take hand gestures as inputs. Immediately, 'Minority Report' came to my mind. A quick glance at the website said that a promising technology is coming up which will make our PCs and Laptops understand finger movements. A software was also being made for this new technology. The technology they were talking about is called Leap Motion.

Leap Motion is actively designed by Leap Motion Company. When I first got to know about it in May 2013, the company was taking pre-orders for the Leap Motion Controller. I researched a bit and figured that my Dell Vostro with Windows 7 was enough to take in the controller. Its price was \$79.99 excluding shipping. I placed an order on a whim as I just wanted to get some taste of gesture recognition technology, and the price seemed justified.

The shipment arrived and it contained one small cardboard box. Inside sat the actual controller which was just 3x1.2x0.5 inches in size. Its top was covered with a black glass, bottom had the Leap Motion logo and an aluminium casing covered its rim. The bundled accessories included a microUSB 3.0 connector, and warranty documentation. The order confirmation mail itself, the company had given 'how to begin' instructions.

As per the instructions, I hooked the controller to my Laptop and checked in to the activation web site. As I opened

an account, the website started downloading the required drivers. Along with the drivers, it also installed Airspace, the app warehouse for Leap Motion. Once the driver installation was complete, I could see the controller working its way through its 'Orientation app'. With the orientation app, I could make waves on the screen ripple by waving my fingers over the controller. You just have to keep the controller device on a surface and any hand movement above is perceived by the controller.

So, the first impression was cool! The installation was extremely easy; the technology showed that it was not totally bogus. But, was it precise enough to do serious work? For that, I had to download a few apps from Airspace. As I browsed through the app collection, I learnt that most of the apps weren't free, though not very costly. So, I downloaded the *Cybermotion* app which allowed you to take apart the bones of a skull apart, and join them again. I had some tough time picking up the movement patterns for *Cybermotion*. But, after some time I could do the maneuvers to move the bones and con-

nect them again. Next I downloaded *Corel Painter* and tried some air-drawing too. But, soon enough I found that keeping your hands aloft and waving is very cumbersome. In no time, my hands got fatigued, and I had to resort to the use of a mouse. My experiments are going on till now with the Leap Motion Controller, and had fun in some of the apps, and for other apps, it was almost unusable.

But, I have learnt that for gesture recognition to be made acceptable to people, developers have to create apps which truly need gesture recognition to function. Most of the reviews of Leap Motion Controller have brought-up the problem of fatigue while using the controller. But, what I feel is that Leap Motion is not there to replace the mouse and keyboard. Our current computer tasks are best done by the mouse and keyboard, and no, gesture recognition can't make them any easier, because the tasks are designed for the mouse and keyboard. So, we should not compare Leap Motion Controller against our mouse and keyboard. There are rumours that this technology will soon feature in smart phones too.

So, am I satisfied with the technology? Yes, for starters it's quite sophisticated and precise. The cost is very reasonable. But, we need software that makes real use of this device. In some fields, gesture recognition would open new ways to use a computer. But, is it time that we all should get one? No! Leap Motion is a novel and innovative idea, but it is not necessary as of now. It's up to the developers to improve upon this technology, maybe then we will see some takers.

Sadly, I could not get the Molecular structure software, which brought up all this. In Airspace, I saw that the free app works only in Mac!



The Leap Motion Controller in action